over the face of a white marble statue. Mass hysteria was alleged; Indian priests (who live off the offerings of devotees in the temples) were merely trying to whip up more custom, said some; it was all politics, said others, pointing to the need for the then-flagging Hindutva movement to attract the credulous to their credo. *The Pioneer* newspaper published a photograph of a spout emerging from the back of a temple from which milk poured into a bucket;[15] the implication was that it was chicanery, not divine ingestion, that accounted for the disappearing milk in the temples. Still, millions of devotees who flocked to temples worldwide saw in the phenomenon a simple message from the heavens that the gods remained interested in the affairs of ordinary mortals.

But Hindus have always believed that to be the case; the 'milk miracle' merely reinforced an unstated assumption about the nature of the godhead. Our gods crowd the streets, smile or frown on us from the skies, jostle us for space on the buses; they are part of our daily lives, as intimate and personal as the towels in which we wrap ourselves after a bath. As MP for Thiruvananthapuram (Trivandrum, in Kerala), I was struck by the fact that my constituency is the one place in the world where even the airport runway shuts down twice a year for a few hours so that Lord Padmanabhaswamy can be escorted on his usual traditional route across the airfield for His ritual seaside bath. And none in the city, of any faith, considers this remotely unusual.

So the intrusion of the gods into our lives through the milk-drinking episode is no great aberration. They are part of our lives anyway; we see ourselves in them, only idealised. My own affection is for Ganesh himself, a god who—overweight, long-nosed, broken-tusked and big-eared—cheerfully reflects our own physical imperfections. After all, a country with many seemingly insurmountable problems needs a god who can overcome obstacles.

When I was a child in Bombay, I was enraptured once a year by the city's great Ganesh Chaturthi festival, in which India's bustling commercial capital gives itself over to the celebration of this many-talented deity. Hundreds of statues of Ganesh are made, decorated and lovingly dressed; then they are taken out across the busy city streets in amid endless processions of followers, who collectively number over a